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Leadership in Digital Context

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Throughout this course, I have had the opportunity to reflect more intentionally on my leadership style, values, goals, and the type of career I want to build. Before this class, I often thought about leadership and professional growth in a very surface-level way, focusing mostly on roles, titles, or future job outcomes. However, through activities like diagnosing organizational culture, identifying my core values, and developing a personal social media strategy, I have gained a clearer understanding of what kind of leader I want to become and what environments I see myself thriving in. This reflection paper connects those experiences and highlights how my values, competencies, and goals align with my interest in pursuing a creative strategy role within the beauty and fashion industry. By examining culture, leadership competencies, personal values, and long-term goals, I am better able to define a path that feels both intentional and authentic to who I am.

For the Diagnosing Organizational Culture activity, I focused on analyzing the culture of The Estée Lauder Companies through its values, leadership style, messaging, and organizational practices. Based on this analysis, Estée Lauder presents a culture that strongly emphasizes creativity, inclusion, empowerment, and ethical leadership. The company consistently frames itself as a family-founded organization with a long-term vision, rooted in values such as respect for the individual, integrity, generosity, and persistence. These values are reinforced through leadership development programs, mentorship initiatives, and a clear commitment to diversity,

equity, and belonging. Leadership within the organization reflects a balance between honoring Estée Lauder's legacy and embracing innovation, creating an environment where employees are encouraged to be authentic, collaborative, and purpose-driven. Overall, the culture communicates that success is not only measured by performance, but by how people are supported, inspired, and empowered within the organization

A career as a creative strategist/marketing & branding in the beauty and fashion industry requires a balance of creativity, emotional intelligence, adaptability, and strong communication skills. Professionals in this field must be able to translate brand values into compelling stories while remaining responsive to trends, digital platforms, and consumer behavior. Collaboration is also essential, as creative strategy often involves working closely with marketing teams, designers, leadership, and external partners. Beyond creativity, success in this field depends on self-awareness, problem-solving skills, and the ability to connect with others on a human level.

I feel particularly well suited for this career because I naturally gravitate toward people-centered and creative work. Through my leadership roles and academic experiences, I have developed strong communication skills, confidence in organizing initiatives, and comfort working in collaborative environments. I value feedback and reflection, which helps me grow creatively and professionally. My ability to connect emotionally with others allows me to approach branding and strategy in a way that feels intentional and authentic rather than forced or transactional.

Several of Ruben's leadership competencies are especially important for a creative strategist role. Communication competencies are critical, as this profession relies heavily on storytelling, framing meaning, and influencing both audiences and internal teams. Personal

competencies, including emotional intelligence and self-awareness, help leaders navigate creative environments and remain grounded under pressure. Analytic competencies are also necessary, as understanding data, audience insights, and performance metrics strengthens creative decision-making. Ruben emphasizes that effective leadership combines horizontal competencies, such as communication and personal skills, with vertical competencies tied to specific industries or roles, which is particularly relevant in the beauty and fashion sector (Ruben, 2012) Experience for this career can be gained through internships, marketing or brand ambassador roles, social media management, and leadership positions within student organizations. Building a personal brand online and actively engaging in creative projects also provides hands-on experience that directly translates to professional creative strategy work.

The Core Values Exercise helped me clarify what truly guides my decisions and how I want to show up professionally. The five values I identified are love, authenticity, success, wisdom, and happiness. Love, to me, means leading with empathy and intention and making others feel valued. In a creative industry, this value encourages work that connects emotionally rather than feeling purely strategic. Authenticity reflects my desire to stay true to myself and create work that feels honest, even when industry pressures push toward trends or curated perfection. Success represents personal fulfillment and pride in meaningful accomplishments rather than just external validation or metrics. Wisdom involves learning from experience, thinking critically, and making thoughtful decisions, especially in fast-paced environments. Finally, happiness reflects my desire for balance and fulfillment, reminding me that long-term success should not come at the cost of well-being. These values align strongly with my interest in creative strategy, but they may occasionally conflict with industry norms that prioritize speed,

visibility, or profit over intention and balance. Recognizing these potential tensions allows me to navigate the industry more intentionally and stay grounded in what matters most to me.

My personal social media strategy focuses on using digital platforms more intentionally for both personal and professional growth. My main goals are to build a stronger personal brand, become more consistent online, and actually leverage the network I have spent years building. Rather than separating my personal and professional identities, I want my online presence to reflect who I am as a creative and emerging leader. By focusing on professional peers such as students, alumni, and early-career professionals in marketing and related fields, I can use platforms like LinkedIn as spaces for branding, engagement, and learning. Sharing leadership experiences, reflecting on projects, and engaging meaningfully with others' content allows me to grow while staying authentic and aligned with my values

One of my short-term goals over the next six to twelve months is to strengthen my personal brand through consistency and intentionality. Specifically, I want to show up more regularly on professional platforms like LinkedIn in a way that reflects my interests in creative strategy, leadership, and personal growth. I will measure this goal by posting or engaging professionally at least twice per week and tracking increases in engagement and meaningful connections. This goal is achievable because it mainly requires structure and discipline rather than new resources. By planning content in advance and holding myself accountable, I can realistically build this habit. This goal is important to me because it supports my values of authenticity and success, while also positioning me more confidently within my desired industry. I aim to achieve this level of consistency within the next year.

A mid-term goal I have for the next two to three years is to secure a full-time creative strategy or brand marketing role within the beauty or fashion industry. This goal is specific in that it focuses on both the function and the industry I want to work in. I will know I have achieved it once I receive and accept an offer in a role that aligns with creative strategy and brand storytelling. While the industry is competitive, this goal is realistic through internships, networking, portfolio-building, and continued skill development. This goal aligns closely with my values of creativity, wisdom, and success, as it allows me to grow professionally while doing work that feels meaningful. I aim to accomplish this within three years as I transition fully into my career.

Looking further ahead, my long-term goal is to grow into a creative leadership role where I can influence brand direction and mentor others. Specifically, I want to hold a position where I am trusted to guide strategy, lead teams, and contribute to a company's larger vision. I will measure this goal by earning leadership responsibilities or promotions over time. This goal is achievable through experience, mentorship, and continuous learning. It is deeply relevant to my values, especially love, wisdom, and happiness, as it allows me to lead with intention while supporting others' growth. I see this goal being achieved within five to seven years as I continue developing professionally and personally.

My mission is to create and lead with intention, authenticity, and heart. I strive to build a career that allows me to connect with people through creativity and storytelling, while staying grounded in empathy and purpose. I want to grow into a leader who inspires others, values meaningful work, and leaves a lasting impact by showing up consistently, thoughtfully, and true to myself.

Overall, this reflection process helped me see how closely my values, goals, and leadership aspirations align. While it required honest self-reflection, it also felt reassuring rather than overwhelming. What surprised me most was how consistently my values showed up across each activity, even when the focus shifted from culture to goals to digital presence. This exercise helped me move beyond vague ideas of success and toward a clearer, more intentional vision for my future. By setting thoughtful goals and defining a personal mission, I feel more confident in navigating my career path while staying grounded in who I am and what matters most to me.